

USE, UNDERSTAND & ENGAGE :

A Digital Media Literacy Framework for Canadian Schools

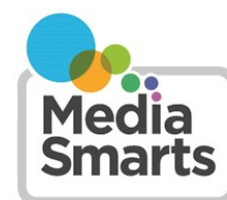
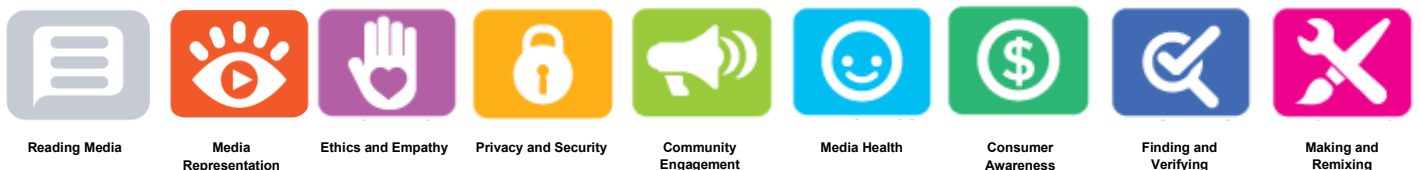
What exactly *is* digital media literacy, and how can we ensure that students are learning the skills they need in school? MediaSmarts classifies competencies for digital media literacy according to four main principles: *access, use, understand* and *engage*. These principles form the basis for our media literacy framework.

Young Canadians need to be able to critically, effectively and responsibly access, use, understand and engage with media of all kinds. Based on our research on digital media literacy education in Canada, *USE, UNDERSTAND & ENGAGE* provides a road map for teaching these skills in Canadian schools. The framework draws on nine key aspects of digital media literacy (listed in the grid below) and provides teachers with supporting lessons and interactive resources that are linked to curriculum outcomes for every province and territory. The home and school connection is supported by parent tip sheets that are linked to from each resource.

To find K-12 lessons in each category, visit <http://mediasmarts.ca/teacher-resources/use-understand-create-digital-literacy-framework-canadian-schools>.

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FRAMEWORK ICON LEGEND



CANADA'S CENTRE
FOR DIGITAL AND
MEDIA LITERACY

Reading Media



The most fundamental digital media literacy topic is learning to “read” the media. Resources in this category teach students how media are made: how different media and genres tell stories and communicate meaning, such as camera angles and editing in film, panel composition and transitions in comics, as well as the affordances and defaults of different networked media.

Media Representation



Media shape how we see reality — whether it's made by professional creators or by our friends and family. This category looks at how media represent reality and how different audiences respond to those representations, covering topics such as stereotyping, how our views of the world and ourselves are shaped by media, how advertising messages manipulate us, and how we represent ourselves on social media.

Ethics and Empathy



This category addresses students' social-emotional skills and empathy towards others as well as their ability to make ethical decisions in digital environments when dealing with issues such as cyberbullying, sharing other people's content and accessing music and video.

Privacy and Security



This includes essential skills for managing students' privacy, reputation and security online such as making good decisions about sharing their own content, understanding data collection techniques, protecting themselves from malware and other software threats, and being aware of their digital footprint.

Community Engagement



Resources in this category teach students about their rights as citizens and consumers and empower them to influence positive social norms in online spaces and to speak out as active, engaged citizens. Students also learn about industry regulatory and self-regulatory bodies and codes, communicating with media makers or industry bodies, and engaging in advocacy through their own media making.

Media Health



Media health skills include analyzing media messages about health, diet, drugs and alcohol, and sexuality; managing screen time and balancing students' online and offline lives; managing online identity issues; dealing with issues relating to digital media, body image and sexuality; and understanding the differences between healthy and unhealthy online relationships.

Consumer Awareness



These skills allow students to navigate highly commercialized online environments. They include recognizing and interpreting advertising, branding and consumerism; reading and understanding the implications of website Terms of Service and privacy policies; and being savvy consumers online. Students also learn about the norms and routines of media industries such as how movies are greenlit and actors are cast, how news outlets decide what stories to cover, and how different media texts are aimed at different audiences.

Finding and Verifying



Students need the skills to effectively search the internet for information they need for personal and school purposes, and then evaluate, authenticate and critique the sources and information they use for school or for personal reasons.

Making and Remixing



Making and Remixing skills enable students to make media and use existing content for their own purposes in ways that respect legal and ethical considerations such as copyright (and with an understanding of their own rights as users and creators) and to use digital platforms to collaborate with others.

Digital Literacy Framework - Grades K-3

Students in the primary grades are already active users of digital technologies, and while they are usually supervised when they go online there are still many issues that need to be considered. For example, younger children (grades K-1) have trouble distinguishing fantasy from reality and tend to accept what they see at face value, including online advertising messages. They trust characters and people they see in the media, which makes them particularly vulnerable to stereotypes.

In grades 2-3, students are still not yet able to think critically about media and technology, accepting online environments and activities at face value. However, their growing independence means they are looking for more information online, and they are starting to integrate computers and the Internet into their daily lives. With this in mind, it's a good time to introduce:

- skills for search strategies
- recognizing how branded characters, games and activities on websites build brand loyalty
- how to protect their privacy on commercial sites
- the persuasive intent of commercials
- the idea that material posted to the Internet can last forever
- the fact that the people we interact with online have feelings

Adversmarts: Introduction to Food Advertising Online

Grades: K-1



In this lesson students are introduced to the idea of online advertising and look at the ways that marketers create immersive and appealing online environments that draw and hold children's attention.

Adversmarts: Understanding Food Advertising Online

Grades: 2-3



In this lesson students are introduced to the idea of online advertising and look at the ways that marketers create immersive and appealing online environments that draw and hold children's attention.

Break the Fake: What's in the frame?

Grades: K-2



In this lesson, students are introduced to the idea that what they see in media can be deceptive. They explore the idea that media are "framed" by their creators and consider what parts of the world are left out of the frame.



Break the Fake: What's Real Online?

Grades: 3-5



In this lesson, students are introduced to the challenges of identifying what is real and what is fake online. After learning some simple steps to verify online information they create a poster that communicates the importance of questioning and double-checking online content.

Can You Spot the Ad?

Grades: K-3



In this lesson students will learn about the concept of branded content and will learn to differentiate between branded images and videos and non-branded images and videos in online and offline contexts.

Co-Co's AdverSmarts: An Interactive Unit on Food Marketing on the Web

Grades: K-3



This interactive unit is designed to help kids recognize the marketing techniques used on commercial websites that target children.

Comparing Real Families to TV Families

Grades: 2-5



Students learn how the media construct reality by studying the families portrayed on television, and comparing them to the real-life families they know: their own, and those of their peers.

Eating Under the Rainbow

Grades 1-3



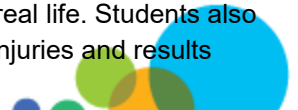
In order to give children a perspective on the lure of snack-food advertisements, it's important that they understand where snacks can fit into a healthy diet. Once they have an understanding of where snack food fits into their lives, they can begin to deconstruct the ads themselves.

Facing Media Violence: Consequences and Media Violence

Grades: 1-4



Students explore the absence, or unrealistic portrayal, of consequences to violence in the media. The class begins with a "what would happen if?" discussion of consequences to violent acts that might occur in real life. Students then complete work sheets where they compare TV depictions of violent acts to what would actually happen in real life. Students also begin to question depicted consequences of media violence based on feelings, responsibilities, injuries and results of actions.



Facing Media Violence: Counting and Discussing Violence

Grades: 1-4



This lesson helps children become aware of the types of violence that appear in media, the frequency with which these acts occur, and how they respond to these acts. It begins with a guided discussion about the different types of violence and then, how violence is portrayed in media.

Facing Media Violence: Rewriting the Story

Grades: 1-4



In this lesson, students explore how characters in media texts resolve conflict, then brainstorm alternative non-violent solutions to conflicts represented in media.

Favourite Sports and Athletes

Grades: K-3



Students talk about the differences between watching sports on TV and in person, and explore the marketing of sports by looking at the sports-related clothing and toys they own. Students also broaden their understanding of sports by reflecting on how they feel when they get hurt in sports and by discussing issues such as the role of women and the disabled in sports.

Finding Balance in our Digital Lives

Grades: K-3



In this lesson students look at the different ways in which we spend our free time and learn to find balance between active, learning and media activities.

Girls and Boys on Television

Grades: 3 to 6



In this lesson, students discuss television programming aimed at children and how girls and boys are portrayed in it. Students illustrate what they dislike about portrayals of girls or boys and then create their own TV character who will counter the illustrated negative portrayals.

Healthy Food Web

Grades: 2-3



In this lesson students consider the role of snack foods in a healthy diet and learn about some of the techniques used by online food marketers.



Internet Time Capsule

Grades: K-3



In this lesson students learn about the concept of “time capsules” and then apply the idea by selecting time capsule contents to represent both the time they live in and their own lives and tastes. They then extend this idea to online content, making a “time capsule” of any online content connected to them.

Introducing TV Families

Grades: 2-5



This lesson encourages children to explore the differences between their real families and TV families by imagining how their own families might be portrayed on a television show. The lesson begins with a class discussion about different types of families. Students then assume the role of producers, and create a television show for their own families to star in.

Looking at Food Advertising

Grades: K-6



This lesson introduces students to the ways in which advertising can affect their food choices. Working from television and magazine ads, students discuss the techniques used by advertisers to engage kids with products. Specifically, they assess the importance of “spokescharacters” and jingles as effective ways to build relationships with kids. As a class exercise, they create jingles and spokescharacters themselves for the foods they enjoy.

Looking at Newspapers

Grades: 2-4



In this lesson, students learn basic information about newspaper journalism through guided class discussion and group and individual activities. Topics include the front page, what’s inside the paper, how to find information, and what elements make up a newspaper story.

Once Upon a Time

Grades: 2-6



Students are introduced to stereotypes by brainstorming the characteristics that are associated with stock characters from fairy tales and Disney films. For younger students, the book *The Paper Bag Princess* is used to illustrate non-stereotypical portrayals of princes and princesses. For older students, *The True Story of the Three Little Pigs* provides an opportunity to discuss how different types of animals - and people - are routinely stereotyped in children’s stories and films.



Packaging Tricks

Grades: K-6



This lesson introduces students to the ways in which packaging is designed to attract kids.

Prejudice and Body Image

Grades: 3-7



Through class discussion and activities, students begin to recognize how the media pressure us to achieve a certain looks and how media images may lead to prejudice against those who don't conform to their standards of attractiveness.

Privacy Pirates: An Interactive Unit on Online Privacy (Ages 7-9)

Grades: 2-4



This tutorial introduces children to the concept of online privacy and teaches them to distinguish between information that is appropriate to give out and information better kept private – and to recognize how this may change in different contexts.

Privacy Pursuit: What is Privacy?

Grades: 2-3



In this lesson, students draw connections between their existing concepts of privacy and how it applies to the internet and networked devices, then learn essential vocabulary relating to privacy. They then consider some scenarios in which children encounter privacy risks and draw on those to develop a list of “dos” and “don’ts” for using networked devices.

Representing Ourselves Online

Grades: K-3



In this lesson students talk about dressing up and taking on identities that are similar to or different from them. They are then introduced to the idea of avatars as a kind of “dressing up” inside video games and consider the ways in which the technical, generic and aesthetic limitations on avatar creation and customization affect their choices and their ability to represent themselves online.

Rules of the Game

Grades: K-3



In this lesson students consider the importance of the written and unwritten rules that make it possible to learn and play together, online and offline.



So Many Choices!

Grades: K-3



In this lesson students are introduced to the first steps in finding information on the Internet.

Teaching Media: Critically Evaluating Media

Grades: 1-6



In this lesson, students learn how media influence how we see the world and send intentional and unintentional messages.

Teaching TV: Film Production: Who Does What?

Grades: 1-6



In this lesson, students look at the equipment used to produce television and film, and learn about the members of the film production team and their duties.

Teaching Media: Learning With Media

Grades: 2-6



In this lesson, students learn about media as a source of information, and how this information is presented from a particular point of view.

Teaching TV: Television as a Story Teller

Grades: 1-6



Students explore the ways in which television tells stories.

Teaching Media: Media Techniques

Grades: 1-6



In this lesson, students learn how different media use different techniques to communicate meaning.

TV Stereotypes

Grades: 2-6



This lesson familiarises students with stereotypes and helps them understand the role that stereotypes play in television's portrayal of life. The lesson begins with a discussion about the types of stereotypes that are common on television, why stereotypes are used on TV, and the possible negative influences of stereotyping.



Villains, Heroes and Heroines

Grades: 3-6



This lesson introduces students to some of the myth-building techniques of television by comparing super heroes and super villains from television to heroes and villains in the real world and by conveying how violence and action are used to give power to characters. Students will also explore the use of stereotypes in the world of TV heroes and villains.

Violence in Sports

Grades: 3-7



The lesson begins with a class discussion about the sports that students participate in, and the rules and consequences that relate to unsporting behaviour. Students then discuss how professional athletes conduct themselves in TV sporting events, and whether the same consequences seem to apply.

Wacky Media Songs: Consumer Awareness

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on recognizing and interpreting advertising, branding and consumerism.

Wacky Media Songs: Community Engagement

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on students' ability to influence positive social norms in online spaces and to speak out as active, engaged citizens.

Wacky Media Songs: Ethics and Empathy

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on students' social-emotional skills and empathy towards others as well as their ability to make ethical decisions in digital environments when dealing with issues such as cyberbullying.

Wacky Media Songs: Finding and Verifying

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on the skills to effectively search the internet for information they need for personal and school purposes, and then evaluate, authenticate and critique the sources and information they use for school or for personal reasons.

Wacky Media Songs: Making and Remixing

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on enabling students to make media and use existing content for their own purposes.

Wacky Media Songs: Media Health

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on analyzing media messages about health and diet; managing screen time and balancing students' online and offline lives; managing online identity issues; dealing with issues relating to digital media, body image and sexuality; and understanding the differences between healthy and unhealthy online relationships.

Wacky Media Songs: Media Representation

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on how media represent reality and how different audiences respond to those representations, covering topics such as stereotyping, how our views of the world and ourselves are shaped by media, how advertising messages manipulate us, and how we represent ourselves on social media.

Wacky Media Songs: Privacy and Security

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on essential skills for managing students' privacy, reputation and security online such as making good decisions about sharing their own content, understanding data collection techniques, protecting themselves from malware and other software threats, and being aware of their digital footprint.

Wacky Media Songs: Reading Media

Grades: K-3



This lesson series contains discussion topics and extension activities for teachers to integrate the TVOKids Original series **Wacky Media Songs**. This lesson focuses on how media are made, how different media and genres tell stories and communicate meaning, and the affordances and defaults of different networked media.



What Do Hallowe'en Costumes Say?

Grades: K-5



This activity is designed to help students look critically at the Halloween costumes marketed to them.



Digital Literacy Framework - Grades 4-6

Students in the junior grades lack sufficient critical thinking skills to surf the Web alone, but MediaSmarts' *Young Canadians in a Wireless World* research shows that almost a third never or rarely use the Internet with an adult nearby. This is also an age where kids may be easily influenced by media images and personalities – especially those that appear "cool" or desirable.

Because they are spending more unsupervised time online, these students need guidance about Internet safety and protection of privacy, and they also need to be taught about good citizenship and responsible Internet use.

As more of their school work requires Internet research, this is also a good time to teach students skills for conducting effective research and for authenticating online content including recognizing marketing messages, bias and stereotyping.

Students at this age are highly active in games and virtual environments, where they need to learn to apply empathy to their online interactions and to resist “upselling” techniques in those environments as well as to manage the amount of time they spend online.

Children this age are also increasingly sensitive to messages about body image and gender norms that they get from media, including digital media, and need help in engaging with these. Despite their growing awareness that media is constructed, they may still be frightened by realistic portrayals of violence, threats or danger – whether on the news or in television dramas.

A Day in the Life of the Jos

Grades: 6-8



In this licensed educational game, students help the brother and sister team Jo and Josie with situations they encounter online as they go about a typical day in their lives. The modules are represented as five days in the lives of Jo and Josie, covering topics that research has identified as being important for youth: defusing drama (cyberbullying), data privacy, privacy and reputation, privacy ethics and authenticating online information.

Advertising All Around Us

Grades: 5-6



This lesson helps students to become more aware of the language and techniques used in print advertising, as well as the impact of advertising on their daily lives.

Avatars and Body Image

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson students are introduced to the concept of “avatars” and share their experiences creating and playing avatars in video games and virtual worlds.



Behaving Ethically Online: Ethics and Empathy

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson students are introduced to the idea that “hot” emotional states such as anger or excitement can make it harder for them to control how they act. They also discuss the concept of empathy and look at the ways in which digital communication can make it harder to feel empathy for other people.

Break the Fake: Verifying Information Online

Grades: 6-9



In this lesson, students participate in a workshop that teaches them four quick, easy steps to verify online information. After practicing these four steps they create a public service announcement aimed at teaching one of these steps and spreading the message that it is necessary for everyone to fact-check information we see online every time we are going to share it or act on it.

Break the Fake: What’s Real Online?

Grades: 3-5



In this lesson, students are introduced to the challenges of identifying what is real and what is fake online. After learning some simple steps to verify online information they create a poster that communicates the importance of questioning and double-checking online content.

Calling Out versus Calling In: Helping youth respond to casual prejudice online

Grades: 6-8



This lesson introduces students to the idea of “calling in” – reaching out to someone privately with the assumption that they didn’t mean to do any harm – and explores how this idea can be applied both to casual prejudice online and when responding to stereotyping and other negative representations in media. Finally, students explore the different benefits of “calling out” and “calling in”, and consider when the two strategies would be most appropriate.

Comic Book Characters

Grades: 5-7



Using a Comic Book Analysis sheet, students will record the attributes of male and female comic book characters. As a class, students will record common attributes on a master sheet and discuss what messages about men and women are reinforced.



Comparing Real Families to TV Families

Grades: 2-5



Students learn how the media construct reality by studying the families portrayed on television, and comparing them to the real-life families they know: their own, and those of their peers.

Cyber Choices

Grades: 3-5



Cyber Choices is an educational game that lets students explore four different stories that cover key issues such as making good choices about their own and others' personal information, dealing with cyberbullying (as both a target and a witness) and managing online conflict.

Data Defenders

Grades: 4-6



This interactive game teaches children and pre-teens the concept of personal information and its economic value, and introduces them to ways to manage and protect their personal information on the websites and apps they enjoy.

Data Defenders: Understanding data collection online

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson, students explore the concepts relating to data collection that are introduced in the educational game Data Defenders. The lesson will underscore for students the idea that their data is valuable and worthy of careful management by analyzing the platforms, applications and websites they use.

Earth Day: Maps as Media

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson, students analyze maps as a medium and discuss how they are created, things they can and can't show, and their effectiveness at communicating environmental information.

Editing Emotions

Grades: 5-9



In this lesson, students learn about the history of film editing and how shot composition, juxtaposition of images and the use of rhythm and repetition in film editing can affect the emotional impact of a film.



Facing Media Violence: Consequences and Media Violence

Grades: 1-4



Students explore the absence, or unrealistic portrayal, of consequences to violence in the media. The class begins with a “what would happen if?” discussion of consequences to violent acts that might occur in real life. Students then complete work sheets where they compare TV depictions of violent acts to what would actually happen in real life. Students also begin to question depicted consequences of media violence based on feelings, responsibilities, injuries and results of actions.

Facing Media Violence: Counting and Discussing Violence

Grades: 1-4



This lesson helps children become aware of the types of violence that appear in media, the frequency with which these acts occur, and how they respond to these acts. It begins with a guided discussion about the different types of violence and then, how violence is portrayed in media.

Facing Media Violence: Rewriting the Story

Grades: 1-4



In this lesson, students explore how characters in media texts resolve conflict, then brainstorm alternative non-violent solutions to conflicts represented in media.

Freedom to Smoke

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson, students explore their beliefs and values about independence – and how cigarette advertising exploits peoples’ desires for greater freedom. Students identify the activities, lifestyles and role models that define the “independent” man and woman in our society. They then analyze ads that associate smoking with images of independence.

Game Time

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson students consider the positive aspects of video games as well as the ways in which games may take time away from other activities they enjoy. Students are introduced to the idea of balancing game and screen time with other parts of their lives and learn about the reasons why they may be tempted to spend more time playing games or find it difficult to stop playing.



Gender Stereotypes and Body Image

Grades: 6-7



This lesson makes students aware of the dangers of gender stereotyping and the media's role in perpetuating gender stereotypes.

Getting the Toothpaste Back into the Tube: A Lesson on Online Information

Grades: 6-8



In this lesson, students watch a short video that compares getting rid of personal information online to getting toothpaste back into a tube. After a short discussion of how visual analogies like this work, students discuss the meaning of the video (that information online is *permanent*.) They then read a series of short scenarios that help them identify four further principles of information online: that it can be *copied*, that it can be seen by *unintended audiences*, that it can be seen by *larger audiences* than intended, and that it becomes *searchable*.

Girls and Boys on Television

Grades: 3 to 6



In this lesson, students discuss television programming aimed at children and how girls and boys are portrayed in it. Students illustrate what they dislike about portrayals of girls or boys and then create their own TV character who will counter the illustrated negative portrayals.

Image Gap

Grades: 5 to 8



This lesson helps students understand how self-image can influence lifestyle choices. Students begin by identifying those qualities they admire most in peers, and by comparing their self-image with these qualities. They learn to identify self-image “problems” and develop positive strategies for dealing with these problems.

Images of Learning

Grades: 6 to 8



This lesson begins with a class discussion about common television stereotypes that are found in the school-based television shows and films that students enjoy. Students respond to questions about television stereotypes and then write a short opinion piece about whether the teachers and students on TV influence their own attitudes about learning. In groups, students create a series outline for their own school-based television show and perform a scene from an episode.



Information Sorting

Grades: 4-8



This is the second lesson in the Critical Thinking Across the Curriculum series, though it can also be delivered independently. In it, students are introduced to the idea of using information sorting to determine whether sources are worth their attention and then to do critical close readings of those that are. After learning and identifying the differences and similarities between the two steps, they learn the characteristics of a reliable source and make a list of companion texts that can be used to determine if a source has those characteristics. After practicing that process, they learn some examples of critical close reading skills and use a possibility grid to do a close reading of a news article. Finally they plan, carry out, and reflect on an information sorting process to make sure they are getting a full and accurate picture of the news story's topic.

Introducing TV Families

Grades: 2-5



This lesson encourages children to explore the differences between their real families and TV families by imagining how their own families might be portrayed on a television show. The lesson begins with a class discussion about different types of families. Students then assume the role of producers, and create a television show for their own families to star in.

Introduction to Cyberbullying: Avatars and Identity

Grades: 5-6



In this lesson students are provided with opportunities to explore the ways that digital media leave out many of the cues that prompt us to feel empathy and discuss the importance of using empathy and common sense when talking to others online.

Is That a Fact?

Grades: 4-8



This is the first lesson in the Critical Thinking Across the Curriculum series, though it can also be delivered independently. In it, students learn the difference between facts and opinions, and distinguish between opinions that are entirely subjective and ones that can be supported by facts. They then learn how to construct and evaluate arguments.



Junk Food Jungle

Grades: 4-6



This lesson familiarizes children with how and why “junk food” is advertised to kids. The lesson starts with an introduction to advertising and a discussion of the gimmicks involved in food advertising to kids. Students discuss the various foods they see advertised in their daily lives versus the ones they don’t see, drawing important points from this data. With this information in mind, students complete an advertising log and also choose an advertisement and analyzing its subject matter in relation to what they have just learned.

Just a joke? Helping youth respond to casual prejudice

Grades: 6-8



One of the barriers to youth pushing back against prejudice is not wanting to over-react, particularly if they feel their peers were just ‘joking around.’ Humour, however, can often be a cover for intentional bullying and prejudice. In this lesson, students analyze media representations of relational aggression, such as sarcasm and put-down humour, then consider the ways in which digital communication may make it harder to recognize irony or satire and easier to hurt someone’s feelings without knowing it. Students then consider how humour may be used to excuse prejudice and discuss ways of responding to it.

Kids, Alcohol and Advertising: Messages About Drinking

Grades: 4-8



Students look at the different groups in our society that deliver messages to the public about drinking and consider the influence of each of these groups on the attitudes and perceptions of young people. Beginning by brainstorming words or ideas associated with the word “beer,” the class develops a mind map of people and organizations that deliver messages to us about alcohol and drinking and the different messages that each provides.

Kids, Alcohol and Advertising: Interpreting Media Messages

Grades: 4-8



In this lesson, students investigate the importance of branding and messaging, especially as they relate to products such as beer and alcohol.

Kids, Alcohol and Advertising: Young Drinkers

Grades: 4-8



Students learn why the alcohol industry needs replacement (new) drinkers and how it exploits the needs and desires of young people in order to foster brand loyalty.



Kids, Alcohol and Advertising: Understanding Brands

Grades: 4-8



In this lesson, students learn about the importance of branding for developing customer loyalty and recognition of products. Through class discussion, students explore different types of brands and the ubiquitous nature of branding in North American culture.

Know the Deal: The Value of Privacy

Grades: 6-8



In this lesson, students are introduced to the idea that privacy is a fundamental human right and that their personal information is valuable.

Looking at Food Advertising

Grades: K-6



This lesson introduces students to the ways in which advertising can affect their food choices. Working from television and magazine ads, students discuss the techniques used by advertisers to engage kids with products. Specifically, they assess the importance of “spokescharacters” and jingles as effective ways to build relationships with kids. As a class exercise, they create jingles and spokescharacters themselves for the foods they enjoy.

Looking at Newspapers

Grades: 2-4



In this lesson, students learn basic information about newspaper journalism through guided class discussion and group and individual activities. Topics include the front page, what’s inside the paper, how to find information, and what elements make up a newspaper story.

Looks Good Enough to Eat

Grades: 5-7



This lesson looks at food photography and the different techniques used by food stylists to make foods look appealing in advertisements. The lesson begins with a discussion about the challenges involved in food photography and how traditional elements of photography may be combined with «food tricks» to achieve the desired effects. After reviewing some food photography «tricks of the trade,» students plan and shoot their own food advertisements.



Media Kids

Grades: 4-7



In this lesson, students deconstruct gender portrayal and depictions of boys and girls in the media. They begin by looking at the appearance and mannerisms of boys and girls in TV, movies, ads and comic books and identify any stereotypes that are used. In a series of group activities, students explore gender stereotypes and representation in greater depth, as well as compare these representations to their own life experiences.

Media Literacy Key Concepts Introduction: What Is Media Anyway?

Grades: 4-6



This opening video to the Key Concepts of Media Literacy video series introduces students to the idea that the word media – which they may already know in the sense of the media industry (“the media”) – means channels of communication between a person or persons and their intended audience. Any form of communication that carries a message is a medium. This can include things students might be aware of, like magazines, television, radio and the Internet; and also less obvious things, like text messages and branded logos on clothes.

Media Literacy Key Concepts Lesson 2: Media are Constructions

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson, students watch a video introducing the media literacy key concept that media are constructions. They then explore this concept by considering a pair of cereal boxes and identifying the different elements of the box and the purposes they serve. In an optional final task, students pick a target audience and create their own cereal box to appeal to that audience.

Media Literacy Key Concepts Lesson 3: Audiences Negotiate Meaning

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson, students watch a video introducing the media literacy key concept that audiences negotiate meaning. They discuss the idea that different media products are aimed at different audiences and that different people may react differently to the same media product, and reflect on the experience of liking something they aren’t “supposed” to.

Media Literacy Key Concepts Lesson 4: Media Have Commercial Considerations

Grades: 5-8



Students watch a video introducing the media literacy key concept that media have commercial implications. They then watch an ad for jeans which conceals its commercial nature, and discuss its purpose before and after being aware of its purpose. In an optional final task, students analyze an educational kids’ website created by the US National Dairy Council and identify the ways in which its different elements educate, entertain, persuade and advertise to youth.



Media Literacy Key Concepts Lesson 5: Media Have Social and Political Implications

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson, students watch a video introducing the media literacy key concept that media have social and political implications. They discuss the idea of explicit messages in media products and then, after watching the video “It’s Not Easy Being Green,” discuss the idea that media products may have less obvious implicit messages. Students apply this analysis to another media work familiar to the class and then, in an optional final task, identify how a favourite media work has influenced them.

Media Literacy Key Concepts Lesson 6: Each Medium Has a Unique Aesthetic Form

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson, students compare print and TV ads for the same product and discuss the advantages and disadvantages of each medium to communicate a particular message. The class then brainstorms a public service message and discusses which medium would be a better way to communicate it and why.

Mirror Image

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson, students analyze their own body image and consider what they wish they could change. They discuss how smoking relates to body image, particularly for young women, and learn about the link between beauty and smoking.

Once Upon a Time

Grades: 2-6



Students are introduced to stereotypes by brainstorming the characteristics that are associated with stock characters from fairy tales and Disney films.

Online Marketing to Kids: Protecting Your Privacy

Grades: 6-9



This two lesson unit on online marketing explores the various ways companies use the Internet to target young people. The first lesson introduces students to the ways in which commercial websites collect personal information from kids and to the issues surrounding children and privacy on the Internet.

Online Marketing to Kids: Strategies and Techniques

Grades: 6-9



The second lesson in the Online Marketing to Kids unit introduces students to the online marketing techniques that are used to target children on the Internet.



Packaging Tricks

Grades: K-6



This lesson introduces students to the ways in which packaging is designed to attract kids.

Pay For Play

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson students discuss their experiences playing free online games and then learn the costs of these “free” games in the form of paying with money, sharing personal information or providing attention to advertising or branded content.

Prejudice and Body Image

Grades: 3-7



Through class discussion and activities, students begin to recognize how the media pressure us to achieve a certain looks and how media images may lead to prejudice against those who don’t conform to their standards of attractiveness.

Privacy Pirates: An Interactive Unit on Online Privacy (Ages 7-9)

Grades: 2-4



This tutorial introduces children to the concept of online privacy and teaches them to distinguish between information that is appropriate to give out and information better kept private – and to recognize how this may change in different contexts.

Privacy Pursuit: Protecting Your Privacy

Grades: 4-5



In this lesson, students review what the word “privacy” means in an online context and learn key privacy-related vocabulary. They explore different privacy risks and then learn practical techniques and strategies to manage and protect their privacy. Students then demonstrate their understanding of these strategies by illustrating them. Finally, students revisit material from earlier in the lesson and consider how their actions might put *other* people’s privacy at risk.

Privacy Pursuit: The Value of Privacy

Grades: 6-7



In this lesson, students learn how their personal information is key to how most of the “free” apps and platforms they use make money. They learn practical strategies and tools for managing their privacy and plan how these can be used to limit what audiences have access to their personal information.



Recognizing Emotional Appeals

Grades: 4-8



This is the third lesson in the Critical Thinking Across the Curriculum series, though it can also be delivered independently. In it, students learn how we can be persuaded by emotional appeals as well as by arguments. After identifying emotionally charged words, they find them in an article and analyze their persuasive effect. Students study a public service announcement to examine how images and story can be emotionally persuasive, then watch a pair of videos to compare how they use emotional persuasion. They then conduct a red teaming exercise to identify the possible risks or drawbacks of using emotional appeals and ways of mitigating those. Finally, they create their own persuasive work using emotionally charged languages, images and music.

Scientific Detectives

Grades: 6-8



In this lesson, students use science and critical thinking to test the legitimacy of advertisers' claims about their products. The lesson begins with students viewing and discussing a series of ads that make claims about their products. Students then conduct their own experiments to see if products live up to their claims.

Stay on the Path Lesson One: Searching for Treasure

Grades: 5-6



This four-lesson unit on search skills and critical thinking teaches students how to target and specify their online searches to avoid unwanted results, how to judge whether a link, search result or website is legitimate or phony and how to find legitimate sources online for media works such as music, videos and movies. In this first lesson students learn how to create well-defined search strings and to use tools and techniques such as bookmarking, browser filters and search engine preferences to avoid unwanted material.

Stay on the Path Lesson Two: All That Glitters is Not Gold

Grades: 5-6



In the second lesson in the *Stay on the Path* lesson unit, students learn how to authenticate online information by comparing "facts" from the website www.allaboutexplorers.com with more authoritative sources.

Stay on the Path Lesson Three: Treasure Maps

Grades: 5-6



In the third lesson in the *Stay on the Path* unit, students apply what they have learned in the first two lessons to find and verify information online.



Stay on the Path Lesson Four: Scavenger Hunt

Grades: 5-6



In the fourth lesson in the *Stay on the Path* unit, students apply their searching and critical thinking skills to learn how to find legitimate online sources for downloading and streaming movies, music and videos.

Stereotyping and Bias

Grades: 5-7



This lesson helps students recognize and understand stereotyping and bias in literature and film.

Taking Charge of TV Violence

Grades: 5-7



Students become aware of the types and amounts of violence in children's programming, and how media violence influences young viewers.

Teaching Media: Critically Evaluating Media

Grades: 1-6



In this lesson, students learn how media influence how we see the world and send intentional and unintentional messages.

Teaching TV: Film Production: Who Does What?

Grades: 1-6



In this lesson, students look at the equipment used to produce television and film, and learn about the members of the film production team and their duties.

Teaching Media: Learning With Media

Grades: 1-6



In this lesson, students learn about media as a source of information, and how this information is presented from a particular point of view.



Teaching TV: Television as a Story Teller

Grades: 1-6



Students explore the ways in which television tells stories.

Teaching Media: Media Techniques

Grades: 1-6



In this lesson, students create their own media productions to learn how television communicates meaning.

The Anatomy of Cool

Grades: 4-7



This lesson helps students become more aware of the media's role in determining what, and who, are perceived as being cool. Through class discussion and activities, students explore the differences between superficial and real "coolness," how marketers use cool to sell products, and how their own attitudes and perceptions are affected by media messages that reinforce specific messages about what coolness is.

The Constructed World of Television Families

Grades: 4-6



In this lesson, students identify the differences between TV families and real families by analyzing the conventions used by TV shows; and by comparing the problems and actions of television families to real world families.

The Hero Project: Authenticating Online Information

Grades: 4-8



In this lesson students are introduced to Internet search skills through researching a personal hero. By focusing on the early parts of the research process, students learn to select well-defined topics, ask relevant research questions and select effective keywords.

Tobacco Labels

Grades: 6-9



Students debate the effectiveness of health warning labels on tobacco products. They begin by looking at different warning labels from around the world, and then focus specifically on Canada's new visual warning labels. Students discuss the elements of effective warning labels, and look at the difficulties of reaching young people with health messages.



TV Dads: Immature and Irresponsible?

Grades: 6-8



Students explore the nature of stereotypes by looking at the negative image of the TV dad as presented in situation comedies (sitcoms) and advertisements.

TV Stereotypes

Grades: 2-6



This lesson familiarises students with stereotypes and helps them understand the role that stereotypes play in television's portrayal of life. The lesson begins with a discussion about the types of stereotypes that are common on television, why stereotypes are used on TV, and the possible negative influences of stereotyping.

Understanding the Internet Lesson 1: Using the Internet

Grades: 4-6



This four lesson unit looks at what the Internet is, how information travels online and how to use the Internet safely for a variety of purposes with a focus on communications. In the first lesson students explore their own experiences with online activities, build a common vocabulary of online-related terminology and identify purposes and methods of online interactions from the user's perspective.

Understanding the Internet Lesson 2: Pathways and Addresses

Grades: 4-6



In the second lesson in the *Understanding the Internet* unit, students gain a greater understanding of how messages are sent and received over the Internet.

Understanding the Internet Lesson 3: Build Understanding

Grades: 4-6



In the third lesson in the *Understanding the Internet* unit students identify and classify their own interactions with the Internet and will engage in a collaborative critical thinking activity that will have them examine the Internet from a variety of perspectives.

Understanding the Internet Lesson 4: Communication and Social Media

Grades: 4-6



In the fourth lesson in the *Understanding the Internet* unit, students compare and contrast a variety of online social networking platforms and build an understanding of how they work to share messages. They will reflect on basic online rules and explore concepts of safety and privacy when accessing and sharing information online.



Villains, Heroes and Heroines

Grades: 3-6



This lesson introduces students to some of the myth-building techniques of television by comparing super heroes and super villains from television to heroes and villains in the real world and by conveying how violence and action are used to give power to characters. Students will also explore the use of stereotypes in the world of TV heroes and villains.

Violence in Sports

Grades: 3-7



The lesson begins with a class discussion about the sports that students participate in, and the rules and consequences that relate to unsporting behaviour. Students then discuss how professional athletes conduct themselves in TV sporting events, and whether the same consequences seem to apply.

What Do Hallowe'en Costumes Say?

Grades: K-5



This activity is designed to help students look critically at the Halloween costumes marketed to them.

Where's The Line?

Grades: 6-8



This lesson promotes safe and informed online behaviour through encouraging youth to make safe, ethical and knowledge-based decisions online and helping youth to identify strategies and supports that are available to assist them with issues they may encounter online.

Who's on First? Alcohol Advertising and Sports

Grades: 6-8



In this lesson, students participate come to better understand their attitudes and perceptions regarding sports and advertising.

Writing a Newspaper Article

Grades: 6-9



The lesson begins with a discussion about freedom of speech and the important role it plays in journalism. Next, students will learn how to create news articles by developing 'lead paragraphs' and by using the 'inverted pyramid' model. Once this is done, they will be given time during class to select topics, conduct research, write their articles and proof read and peer edit their own and other's works.



Winning the Cyber Security Game

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson students discuss their online experiences and learn how to minimize the potential risks that may be associated with them.

You've Gotta Have a Gimmick

Grades: 5-7



This lesson familiarizes students with the marketing techniques used in television and magazine snack food ads.



Digital Literacy Framework - Grades 7-8

Intermediate students still need continued guidance regarding Internet safety and protection of privacy, good citizenship and responsible Internet use. By this age, however, they can also assume more responsibility for the online spaces and communities they are part of: this is a good time to encourage positive social norms around sharing information and communicating online. Teens also depend on media such as TV shows, magazines and the internet to learn about topics of interest, especially subjects that are embarrassing or taboo such as sexuality, relationships and mental health issues.

Given their increasing use of the Internet to find information, now is also a good time to introduce strategies for determining authorship and authority of online information so they can recognize good health information, biased or hateful content, and online scams and hoaxes.

At this age media influences on gender norms and body image are becoming more intense. Children need to learn to apply key media literacy concepts to online spaces such as social networks.

Children this age are also starting to form more intense friendships and, in some cases, beginning romantic relationships, as well as sharing more personal content online. They need to learn to recognize the qualities of healthy and unhealthy relationships and to make good choices about how they handle others' personal information.

A Day in the Life of the Jos

Grades: 6-8



In this licensed educational game, students help the brother and sister team Jo and Josie with situations they encounter online as they go about a typical day in their lives. The modules are represented as five days in the lives of Jo and Josie, covering topics that research has identified as being important for youth: defusing drama (cyberbullying), data privacy, privacy and reputation, privacy ethics and authenticating online information.

Behaving Ethically Online: Ethics and Values

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson students consider how we come to hold values and how they affect our behaviour, especially online.

Beyond Media Messages: Media Portrayal of Global Development

Grades: 7-12



Students explore how sensationalism plays a role in determining what is newsworthy, and how that can distort our perception of issues in developing nations. What makes a story newsworthy? What positive results follow the natural disasters and how, where and when are those reported in the media? How do distorted perceptions of developing nations affect our attitudes and behaviours toward them?



Bias and Crime in Media

Grades: 7-12



Students are introduced to the key media literacy concept that media are constructions that re-present reality and consider how representations of crime in news and entertainment media may influence how we perceive members of particular groups. The concept that media communicate values and messages and have social implications is introduced and students discuss how stereotypes of particular groups are formed.

Break the Fake: Verifying Information Online

Grades: 6-9



In this lesson, students participate in a workshop that teaches them four quick, easy steps to verify online information. After practicing these four steps they create a public service announcement aimed at teaching one of these steps and spreading the message that it is necessary for everyone to fact-check information we see online every time we are going to share it or act on it.

Buy Nothing Day

Grades: 7-12



Buy Nothing Day is used as a jumping-off point to look at the role of consumerism in our lives and culture. Students learn the definition of consumerism and consider its benefits and drawbacks; as well as where and how they receive consumerist messages. Students list their own recent purchases and consider how many were needed as opposed to wanted. They are then introduced to Buy Nothing Day and discuss its purpose and merits. Finally, students imagine that Buy Nothing Day is a holiday on par with Christmas and plan either a pageant or television program to celebrate the event.

Calling Out versus Calling In: Helping youth respond to casual prejudice online

Grades: 6-8



This lesson introduces students to the idea of “calling in” – reaching out to someone privately with the assumption that they didn’t mean to do any harm – and explores how this idea can be applied both to casual prejudice online and when responding to stereotyping and other negative representations in media. Finally, students explore the different benefits of “calling out” and “calling in”, and consider when the two strategies would be most appropriate.

Celebrities and World Issues

Grades: 7-12



Students examine the role of popular culture celebrities in creating awareness of world issues, then debate whether celebrity involvement is important and positive, or whether such involvement brings too much attention to the celebrities themselves, overshadowing the central messages of a campaign, organization, program or issue.



Comic Book Characters

Grades: 5-7



Using a Comic Book Analysis sheet, students will record the attributes of male and female comic book characters. As a class, students will record common attributes on a master sheet and discuss what messages about men and women are reinforced.

Click if You Agree

Grades: 7-8



Think you know how to read and understand privacy policies and terms of use? Learn how to make sense of legal documents for websites and apps with this interactive game. Includes a Teacher's Guide for implementing the activity in the classroom.

Cyberbullying and Civic Participation

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson students explore the concepts of rules, values and ethics and learn how they influence our decision-making, and how they can contribute to creating positive online cultures.

Cyberbullying and the Law

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson students learn about and discuss the legal aspects of cyberbullying. They review a variety of hypothetical scenarios and a case study, and they consider the seriousness of the situations, who is legally responsible, what action (if any) should be taken and by whom.

Deconstructing Web Pages

Grades: 7-10



In this lesson students apply the "5Ws of Cyberspace" to sources of information they find online. Assuming the role of a student researching a science project, students must authenticate the information in an online article about the artificial sweetener aspartame.



Digital Media Experiences are Shaped by the Tools We Use: The Disconnection Challenge

Grades: 7-12



In this lesson, students consider the role of technology and media in their lives and then spend a week either tracking or limiting their media use. They then share their experiences and discuss how the ways that digital media tools are made may cause us to use them differently (or simply more often). Finally, students draw on those insights to create a mindful media use plan. In an optional extension activity, they interview other students for a video exploring their experiences and reflections over the course of the project.

Do Sharks Love Ice Cream?

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students learn how science news articles are written and how to read them with a critical eye. They analyze elements such as peer review, correlation, and bias, and then write a science article based on an actual press release.

Editing Emotions

Grades: 5-9



In this lesson, students learn about the history of film editing and how shot composition, juxtaposition of images and the use of rhythm and repetition in film editing can affect the emotional impact of a film.

Exposing Gender Stereotypes

Grades: 8-9



In this lesson students take a look at their own assumptions about what it means to be a man, and what it means to be a woman. Students will begin to see how believing in stereotypes can lead to violence towards oneself and others.

Finding and Authenticating Online Information on Global Development Issues

Grades: 7-12



In this lesson students learn strategies for using the Internet effectively to research global development issues.

Freedom to Smoke

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson, students explore their beliefs and values about independence – and how cigarette advertising exploits peoples' desires for greater freedom. Students identify the activities, lifestyles and role models that define the "independent" man and woman in our society. They then analyze ads that associate smoking with images of independence.



Gender and Tobacco

Grades: 7-9



Students explore gender-related influences on smoking. They discuss the numbers of male and female smokers in Canada and around the world, and the strategies used by tobacco companies to reach both men and women. In separate groups, male and female students explore and discuss the relationship between smoking, the tobacco industry, tobacco marketing, and their gender, by deconstructing and analyzing tobacco ads from magazines for men, for women, and for a general audience.

Gender Messages in Alcohol Advertising

Grades: 7-10



In this lesson students learn to think critically about culturally inherited gender stereotypes, and explore how stereotypes about men and women are promoted and reinforced through the images and messages in alcohol ads.

Gender Stereotypes and Body Image

Grades: 6-7



This lesson makes students aware of the dangers of gender stereotyping and the media's role in perpetuating gender stereotypes.

Getting the Toothpaste Back into the Tube: A Lesson on Online Information

Grades: 6-8



In this lesson, students watch a short video that compares getting rid of personal information online to getting toothpaste back into a tube. After a short discussion of how visual analogies like this work, students discuss the meaning of the video (that information online is *permanent*.) They then read a series of short scenarios that help them identify four further principles of information online: that it can be *copied*, that it can be seen by *unintended audiences*, that it can be seen by *larger audiences* than intended, and that it becomes *searchable*.

Hate 2.0

Grades: 8-10



In this lesson students learn about the ways in which hate may be encountered online strategies for confronting online hate.



Hate or Debate?

Grades 8-10



In this lesson students learn about the difference between legitimate debate on a political issue and arguments that are based on hate.

I heard it 'round the Internet: Sexual health education and authenticating online information

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students consider the use of the Internet as a research tool and learn how to use search engines more effectively. They then apply these newfound skills to investigating popular myths about sexuality and contraception.

Image Gap

Grades: 5 to 8



This lesson helps students understand how self-image can influence lifestyle choices. Students begin by identifying those qualities they admire most in peers, and by comparing their self-image with these qualities. They learn to identify self-image “problems” and develop positive strategies for dealing with these problems.

Images of Learning

Grades: 6 to 8



This lesson begins with a class discussion about common television stereotypes that are found in the school-based television shows and films that students enjoy. Students respond to questions about television stereotypes and then write a short opinion piece about whether the teachers and students on TV influence their own attitudes about learning. In groups, students create a series outline for their own school-based television show and perform a scene from an episode.

Impact! How to Make a Difference When You Witness Bullying Online

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students discuss reasons why they might be reluctant to intervene when they witness cyberbullying and identify ways that they can help without making things worse. They then use the interactive tool *Impact! How to Make a Difference When You Witness Bullying Online* to help them decide how to navigate scenarios relating to being a witness to bullying, and share their experiences to help them understand how important it is to think carefully before you act.



Information Sorting

Grades: 4-8



This is the second lesson in the Critical Thinking Across the Curriculum series, though it can also be delivered independently. In it, students are introduced to the idea of using information sorting to determine whether sources are worth their attention and then to do critical close readings of those that are. After learning and identifying the differences and similarities between the two steps, they learn the characteristics of a reliable source and make a list of companion texts that can be used to determine if a source has those characteristics. After practicing that process, they learn some examples of critical close reading skills and use a possibility grid to do a close reading of a news article. Finally they plan, carry out, and reflect on an information sorting process to make sure they are getting a full and accurate picture of the news story's topic.

Is That a Fact?

Grades: 4-8



This is the first lesson in the Critical Thinking Across the Curriculum series, though it can also be delivered independently. In it, students learn the difference between facts and opinions, and distinguish between opinions that are entirely subjective and ones that can be supported by facts. They then learn how to construct and evaluate arguments.

Just a joke? Helping youth respond to casual prejudice

Grades: 6-8



One of the barriers to youth pushing back against prejudice is not wanting to over-react, particularly if they feel their peers were just 'joking around.' Humour, however, can often be a cover for intentional bullying and prejudice. In this lesson, students analyze media representations of relational aggression, such as sarcasm and put-down humour, then consider the ways in which digital communication may make it harder to recognize irony or satire and easier to hurt someone's feelings without knowing it. Students then consider how humour may be used to excuse prejudice and discuss ways of responding to it.

Kids, Alcohol and Advertising: Messages About Drinking

Grades: 4-8



Students look at the different groups in our society that deliver messages to the public about drinking and consider the influence of each of these groups on the attitudes and perceptions of young people. Beginning by brainstorming words or ideas associated with the word "beer," the class develops a mind map of people and organizations that deliver messages to us about alcohol and drinking and the different messages that each provides.

Kids, Alcohol and Advertising: Interpreting Media Messages

Grades: 4-8



In this lesson, students investigate the importance of branding and messaging, especially as they relate to products such as beer and alcohol.



Kids, Alcohol and Advertising: Young Drinkers

Grades: 4-8



Students learn why the alcohol industry needs replacement (new) drinkers and how it exploits the needs and desires of young people in order to foster brand loyalty.

Kids, Alcohol and Advertising: Understanding Brands

Grades: 4-8



In this lesson, students learn about the importance of branding for developing customer loyalty and recognition of products. Through class discussion, students explore different types of brands and the ubiquitous nature of branding in North American culture.

Know the Deal: The Value of Privacy

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson, students are introduced to the idea that privacy is a fundamental human right and that their personal information is valuable.

Learning Gender Stereotypes

Grades: 8-9



Students deconstruct a series of advertisements based on gender representation and answer questions about gender stereotyping about articles they have read.

Looks Good Enough to Eat

Grades: 5-7



This lesson looks at food photography and the different techniques used by food stylists to make foods look appealing in advertisements. The lesson begins with a discussion about the challenges involved in food photography and how traditional elements of photography may be combined with «food tricks» to achieve the desired effects. After reviewing some food photography «tricks of the trade,» students plan and shoot their own food advertisements.

Marketing to Teens: Alternate Ads

Grades: 8-12



In this lesson students look at the less obvious methods used by advertisers to reach consumers: humorous, self-deprecating ads, product placement, product association with celebrities, ads promoting empowerment and affirmation and 'advocacy' advertising.



Marketing to Teens: Gender Roles in Advertising

Grades: 8-12



Students explore gender roles in advertising by taking an ad campaign they have seen which is specifically directed to one gender, and redesigning the campaign to target the opposite gender.

Marketing to Teens: Gotta Have It! Designer and Brand Names

Grades: 8-12



Students identify how we associate social status with designer and brand name products, and how we believe others perceive us by what we wear.

Marketing to Teens: Marketing Tactics

Grades: 8-12



This activity helps teenagers develop an awareness of marketing tactics aimed at teens through the creation of their own mock advertising campaigns.

Marketing to Teens: Parody Ads

Grades: 8-12



In this lesson students explore what's hidden behind advertising messages by analysing and creating parody advertisements.

Marketing to Teens: Talking Back

Grades: 8-12



This lesson helps teens become active consumers by encouraging them to 'talk back' to advertisers when they have concerns.

Media Kids

Grades: 4-7



In this lesson, students deconstruct gender portrayal and depictions of boys and girls in the media. They begin by looking at the appearance and mannerisms of boys and girls in TV, movies, ads and comic books and identify any stereotypes that are used. In a series of group activities, students explore gender stereotypes and representation in greater depth, as well as compare these representations to their own life experiences.



Media Literacy Key Concepts Lesson 3: Audiences Negotiate Meaning

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson, students watch a video introducing the media literacy key concept that audiences negotiate meaning. They discuss the idea that different media products are aimed at different audiences and that different people may react differently to the same media product, and reflect on the experience of liking something they aren't "supposed" to.

Media Literacy Key Concepts Lesson 4: Media Have Commercial Considerations

Grades: 5-8



Students watch a video introducing the media literacy key concept that media have commercial implications. They then watch an ad for jeans which conceals its commercial nature, and discuss its purpose before and after being aware of its purpose. In an optional final task, students analyze an educational kids' website created by the US National Dairy Council and identify the ways in which its different elements educate, entertain, persuade and advertise to youth.

Media Literacy Key Concepts Lesson 5: Media Have Social and Political Implications

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson, students watch a video introducing the media literacy key concept that media have social and political implications. They discuss the idea of explicit messages in media products and then, after watching the video "It's Not Easy Being Green," discuss the idea that media products may have less obvious implicit messages. Students apply this analysis to another media work familiar to the class and then, in an optional final task, identify how a favourite media work has influenced them.

Mirror Image

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson, students analyze their own body image and consider what they wish they could change. They discuss how smoking relates to body image, particularly for young women, and learn about the link between beauty and smoking.

Mixed Signals: Verifying Online Information

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students examine two websites about unlikely animals and learn how to effectively evaluate online sources. They then create a fake website that demonstrates the misleading signals that are often mistakenly taken as signs of reliability.



Online Marketing to Kids: Protecting Your Privacy

Grades: 6-9



This two lesson unit on online marketing explores the various ways companies use the Internet to target young people. The first lesson introduces students to the ways in which commercial websites collect personal information from kids and to the issues surrounding children and privacy on the Internet.

Online Marketing to Kids: Strategies and Techniques

Grades: 6-9



The second lesson in the Online Marketing to Kids unit introduces students to the online marketing techniques that are used to target children on the Internet.

Perceptions of Youth and Crime

Grades: 7-12



In this lesson students develop an awareness of the ways in which public perceptions regarding young people have been affected by media portrayals of youth violence and youth crime.

Playing With Privacy

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson students are introduced to the idea that their gaming experiences may compromise their personal information. Students consider the ways in which games may gather or solicit information about them and learn about tools which they can use to control their personal privacy, and then discuss the trade-offs between protecting their privacy and enjoying a full game experience.

Police in Media

Grades: 7-12



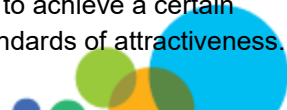
This lesson helps students understand the different perceptions of the police force portrayed in the media. Students will learn about the differences between the constructed reality of media and law enforcement in real life and then create their television “cop shows” that provide a more accurate picture of policing.

Prejudice and Body Image

Grades: 3-7



Through class discussion and activities, students begin to recognize how the media pressure us to achieve a certain looks and how media images may lead to prejudice against those who don't conform to their standards of attractiveness.



Privacy Pursuit: My Privacy, Your Privacy

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson, students start by considering the permanence of online content. They review privacy strategies and privacy risks and analyze how likely and severe different privacy risks are. They then consider how their actions and decisions can affect *others'* privacy and develop a list of “Dos and Don’ts” for managing both their own and others’ privacy.

Privacy Pursuit: The Value of Privacy

Grades: 6-7



In this lesson, students learn how their personal information is key to how most of the “free” apps and platforms they use make money. They learn practical strategies and tools for managing their privacy and plan how these can be used to limit what audiences have access to their personal information.

Promoting Ethical Behaviour Online

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students learn about ways to manage their privacy and reputation online by exploring their digital presence and to make good choices about sharing other people’s content online.

PushBack: Engaging in Online Activism

Grades: 7-9



This lesson explores how young people can use online media for activism on issues that matter to them.

Put Your Best Face Forward

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students start by discussing the phenomenon of “selfies” and serve as experts in advising the teacher on the standards by which the “best” selfies are judged. They then discuss a number of statements taken from interviews with youth that highlight issues of self-representation, body image and gender standards, and learn about “photoshopping” images.



Recognizing Emotional Appeals

Grades: 4-8



This is the third lesson in the Critical Thinking Across the Curriculum series, though it can also be delivered independently. In it, students learn how we can be persuaded by emotional appeals as well as by arguments. After identifying emotionally charged words, they find them in an article and analyze their persuasive effect. Students study a public service announcement to examine how images and story can be emotionally persuasive, then watch a pair of videos to compare how they use emotional persuasion. They then conduct a red teaming exercise to identify the possible risks or drawbacks of using emotional appeals and ways of mitigating those. Finally, they create their own persuasive work using emotionally charged languages, images and music.

Scapegoating and Othering

Grades: 8-10



In this lesson students develop a deeper understanding of scapegoating and othering and how these factors may contribute to the promotion of hatred and intolerance.

Scientific Detectives

Grades: 6-8



In this lesson, students use science and critical thinking to test the legitimacy of advertisers' claims about their products. The lesson begins with students viewing and discussing a series of ads that make claims about their products. Students then conduct their own experiments to see if products live up to their claims.

Selling Tobacco

Grades: 7-10



In this lesson, students explore how tobacco advertising has evolved over the past century.

Sports Personalities in Magazine Advertising

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students explore the relationship between athletes and advertising through a number of different activities.

Stereotyping and Bias

Grades: 5-7



This lesson helps students recognize and understand stereotyping and bias in literature and film by looking at representations of wolves.



Taking Charge of TV Violence

Grades: 5-7



Students become aware of the types and amounts of violence in children's programming, and how media violence influences young viewers.

Taming the Wild Wiki

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students are introduced to Wikipedia, the user-edited online encyclopedia, and given an overview of its strengths and weaknesses as a research source. They are taught how to evaluate the reliability of a Wikipedia article and then attempt to improve an existing article.

That's Not Cool: Healthy and Respectful Relationships Online

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson, students explore unhealthy relationship behaviours relating to digital media including: pressuring others to share private content, cyberstalking, harassment and abuse of trust.

The Anatomy of Cool

Grades: 4-7



This lesson helps students become more aware of the media's role in determining what, and who, are perceived as being cool. Through class discussion and activities, students explore the differences between superficial and real "coolness," how marketers use cool to sell products, and how their own attitudes and perceptions are affected by media messages that reinforce specific messages about what coolness is.

The Girl in the Mirror

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students look at how gender stereotyping may discourage young women from becoming involved in politics.

The Hero Project: Authenticating Online Information

Grades: 4-8



In this lesson students are introduced to Internet search skills through researching a personal hero. By focusing on the early parts of the research process, students learn to select well-defined topics, ask relevant research questions and select effective keywords.



The Impact of Gender Stereotypes

Grades: 8-9



The lesson begins with a discussion about how self-violence may be promoted by the fashion industry when men and women put their health at risk to attain impossible standards of attractiveness and thinness. Students also explore how stereotypes about masculinity can fuel male violence.

The Invisible Machine: Big Data and You

Grades: 8-10



In this lesson, students examine a fictional social network profile to learn how online platforms collect data about their users. They then read an article that explains how platforms use this data and explores some of the issues this raises. Finally, they create a mind map of their own online data profile and reflect on how the data they post may be collected and used by others.

The Price of Happiness

Grades: 8-12



Students answer a brief questionnaire related to self-image, self-esteem, and advertising, and then work as groups to create and act in mock television commercials that parody advertising techniques.

Thinking About Hate

Grades: 8-10



In this lesson students develop their critical thinking skills by learning to recognize various types of logical fallacies, including those that are used by hate mongers to spread misinformation and fuel hatred and intolerance.

Thinking Like a Tobacco Company

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students learn how the tobacco industry targets the needs, wishes and desires of young people in order to sell cigarettes. Students begin by looking at the reasons why the tobacco industry needs to recruit “replacement” smokers. Then they assume the roles of marketing personnel in a tobacco company and use a 1987 youth survey conducted by R. J. Reynolds Tobacco to create their own marketing campaigns to sway various sub-groups within the youth demographic.



Tobacco Labels

Grades: 6-9



Students debate the effectiveness of health warning labels on tobacco products. They begin by looking at different warning labels from around the world, and then focus specifically on Canada's new visual warning labels. Students discuss the elements of effective warning labels, and look at the difficulties of reaching young people with health messages.

Understanding Cyberbullying : Virtual vs. Physical Worlds

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson students explore the verbal and visual cues that we rely on to understand how other people are feeling. They then consider the differences between online and offline communication and discuss how these differences may make it difficult to understand the effect our words and actions have on others online.

Unpacking Privilege

Grades: 7-12



Students are introduced to the idea of "privilege" in relation to diversity and how it applies to media. They then look at a checklist of media related privileges to help them understand the concept.

Up, Up and Away!

Grades: 7-8



In this lesson students encounter the key concepts of intellectual property, learning the difference between copyright and trademark and coming to understand how these affect how media products are created and sold.

Video Games

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students are introduced to the ways video games may impact their mental and physical health.

Violence in Sports

Grades: 3-7



The lesson begins with a class discussion about the sports that students participate in, and the rules and consequences that relate to unsporting behaviour. Students then discuss how professional athletes conduct themselves in TV sporting events, and whether the same consequences seem to apply.



Watching the Elections

Grades: 8-12



Students look at how elections are media events, then compare American and Canadian elections to other mass media events and then watch one or both debates with an eye to analyzing them as media constructs. Students will then study advertising techniques frequently used in political ads, then watch American and Canadian campaign ads from past years.

Where's The Line?

Grades: 6-8



This lesson promotes safe and informed online behaviour through encouraging youth to make safe, ethical and knowledge-based decisions online and helping youth to identify strategies and supports that are available to assist them with issues they may encounter online.

Who's on First? Alcohol Advertising and Sports

Grades: 6-8



In this lesson, students participate come to better understand their attitudes and perceptions regarding sports and advertising.

Winning the Cyber Security Game

Grades: 5-8



In this lesson students discuss their online experiences and learn how to minimize the potential risks that may be associated with them.

Writing a Newspaper Article

Grades: 6-9



The lesson begins with a discussion about freedom of speech and the important role it plays in journalism. Next, students will learn how to create news articles by developing 'lead paragraphs' and by using the 'inverted pyramid' model. Once this is done, they will be given time during class to select topics, conduct research, write their articles and proof read and peer edit their own and other's works.

You've Gotta Have a Gimmick

Grades: 5-7



This lesson familiarizes students with the marketing techniques used in television and magazine snack food ads.



Digital Media Literacy Framework - Grades 9-12

Given their autonomy, teens can no longer be forbidden to do things, especially online. Rigid bans don't work because teens are at an age where they are trying to establish their own rules and can easily get around those they disagree with. More importantly, heavy restrictions shut down discussions between adults and teens about how to safely diminish risks, which teens are very interested in doing.

Contrary to popular belief, cyberbullying remains a problem in high school. Students in these grades should learn the ways that they can speak out and make a difference, both in cases of individual cyberbullying and in building more tolerant and respectful online spaces.

Smartphone ownership also peaks in older grades. That makes it essential to teach these students how to balance their online and offline lives and deal with the stresses of social media. Because teens are constantly building a digital footprint as they send and share content online, it's also important that they learn how to make a positive impression and to consider the need to get consent before sharing a photo or any other content belonging to someone else.

Secondary students turn to the internet for news and current affairs, making it essential that they learn to use finding and verifying skills both inside and outside the classroom.

Teens depend on media such as TV shows, magazines, the Web and social media to learn about topics of interest, especially subjects that are embarrassing or taboo such as sexuality, relationships and mental health issues. Digital media literacy education is also needed to critically engage with representations of sexuality in media.

Alcohol and Male Violence

Grades: 9-12



This lesson makes students aware of the ways in which male violence is used and promoted in advertising.

Alcohol on the Web

Grades: 9-10



In this lesson, students explore issues surrounding the marketing of alcoholic beverages on the Internet.

Art Exchange

Grades: 9-12



The purpose of the lesson is to facilitate and develop youth art as a form of community engagement and give students the opportunity to explore their experiences with privacy and equality in networked spaces.



Authentication Beyond the Classroom

Grades: 9-10



In this lesson, students discuss “viral” photos, videos and news stories that spread via social media. They are shown how challenging it is to authenticate these using only their content and are introduced to tools and techniques for gauging their accuracy based on context.

Beyond Media Messages: Media Portrayal of Global Development

Grades: 7-12



Students explore how sensationalism plays a role in determining what is newsworthy, and how that can distort our perception of issues in developing nations. What makes a story newsworthy? What positive results follow the natural disasters and how, where and when are those reported in the media? How do distorted perceptions of developing nations affect our attitudes and behaviours toward them?

Bias and Crime in Media

Grades: 7-12



Students are introduced to the key media literacy concept that media are constructions that re-present reality and consider how representations of crime in news and entertainment media may influence how we perceive members of particular groups. The concept that media communicate values and messages and have social implications is introduced and students discuss how stereotypes of particular groups are formed.

Bias in News Sources

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson students consider the meaning of the words “bias” and “prejudice” and consider how bias may be found even at the level of individual words due to connotation. Students are introduced to the key media literacy concept that media contain ideological messages and have social and political implications in considering why it is particularly important to consider possible bias in news reporting.

Body image and social media: Escaping the comparison trap

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students consider the ways in which social media may prompt them to compare themselves with others, and the impacts that can have on body image and self-esteem. They analyze how the features, algorithms and culture of the social networks they use may affect them and will produce “paper prototypes” of redesigned social media apps that promote more healthful use. Finally, students reflect on how they can change how they use the existing apps to be more like their redesigned versions.



Body Positive Ads

Grades: 9-12



Students begin by reading about the impact that body positive advertising campaigns have on companies, as well as on their consumers. They look at body positive ads aimed towards men and read research about how there is a lack of representation in this field, then deconstruct a series of traditional ads compared to body positive ones and discuss how marketers target "ideal beauty" messages to both men and women and whether they are effective.

Break the Fake: Hoax? Scholarly Research? Personal Opinion? You Decide!

Grades: 10-12



This lesson is designed to help students determine the validity of information that is presented to them on the Internet. After reviewing a series of evaluation techniques for online resources, students form groups to assess selected websites based on accuracy and authority, advocacy and objectivity, and currency and coverage.

Break the Fake: Verifying Information Online

Grades: 6-9



In this lesson, students participate in a workshop that teaches them four quick, easy steps to verify online information. After practicing these four steps they create a public service announcement aimed at teaching one of these steps and spreading the message that it is necessary for everyone to fact-check information we see online every time we are going to share it or act on it.

Buy Nothing Day

Grades: 7-12



Buy Nothing Day is used as a jumping-off point to look at the role of consumerism in our lives and culture. Students learn the definition of consumerism and consider its benefits and drawbacks; as well as where and how they receive consumerist messages. Students list their own recent purchases and consider how many were needed as opposed to wanted. They are then introduced to Buy Nothing Day and discuss its purpose and merits. Finally, students imagine that Buy Nothing Day is a holiday on par with Christmas and plan either a pageant or television program to celebrate the event.

Celebrities and World Issues

Grades: 7-12



Students examine the role of popular culture celebrities in creating awareness of world issues, then debate whether celebrity involvement is important and positive, or whether such involvement brings too much attention to the celebrities themselves, overshadowing the central messages of a campaign, organization, program or issue.



Camera Shots

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students examine the visual codes used on television and in movies through an exploration of various camera techniques.

Challenging Hate Online

Grades: 10-12



In this lesson students learn how digital media is used to promote or combat hatred and intolerance.

Click if You Agree

Grades: 7-9



This interactive game helps students make sense of legal documents for websites and apps.

Consensus or Conspiracy?

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students learn the definition of scientific consensus and distinguish it from conventional wisdom. They explore how consensus is formed and how new data can lead to it changing. Students then use digital tools to identify the consensus on a topic. Next, students learn how fringe theories can do harm and learn the characteristics of a conspiracy theory. Finally, students show their learning through creating a graphic organizer; in an optional activity, students then adapt the graphic organizer to a poster showing how to recognize a conspiracy theory.

Crime in the News

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson students explore the commercial and ethical issues surrounding the reporting of crime in televised newscasts.

Cyberbullying and the Law

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students learn about and discuss the legal aspects of cyberbullying.



Dealing With Digital Stress

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson students reflect on the ways in which digital media can cause stress.

Deconstructing Web Pages

Grades: 7-10



In this lesson students apply the “5Ws of Cyberspace” to sources of information they find online. Assuming the role of a student researching a science project, students must authenticate the information in an online article about the artificial sweetener, aspartame.

Digital Media Experiences are Shaped by the Tools We Use: The Disconnection Challenge

Grades : 7-12



In this lesson, students consider the role of technology and media in their lives and then spend a week either tracking or limiting their media use. They then share their experiences and discuss how the ways that digital media tools are made may cause us to use them differently (or simply more often). Finally, students draw on those insights to create a mindful media use plan. In an optional extension activity, they interview other students for a video exploring their experiences and reflections over the course of the project.

Digital Outreach for Civic Engagement

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students will design a community outreach promotional campaign in order to effect real change that matters to them.

Digital Skills for Democracy: Assessing Online Information to Make Civic Choices

Grades: 9-12



In this activity, students think about the importance of making sure they have trustworthy information before they make a decision on a political or electoral issue and reflect on the impact of false and misleading information in politics.

Digital Storytelling for Civic Engagement

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students will create a Digital Story which addresses a topic, theme or issue that is affecting them. All stages of production will be covered, including research, storyboarding their idea into a visual organizational layout, practicing capturing quality photographs and interviews, and finally weaving their Digital Story into a finished project using computer editing software.



Diversity and Media Ownership

Grades: 9-12



Students are introduced to the media literacy key concepts that “media are created to re-present reality” and “media are influenced by commercial considerations.” They then read one of two articles – one is an overview of minority-focused media in Canada, the other is a more personal account of Michaëlle Jean’s experiences as an African-Canadian journalist in Quebec – and consider the importance of media ownership, the relative roles of minority-focused and mainstream media in reflecting and promoting Canadian multiculturalism, and changes in minority participation and representation in Canadian media.

Do Sharks Love Ice Cream?

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students learn how science news articles are written and how to read them with a critical eye. They analyze elements such as peer review, correlation, and bias, and then write a science article based on an actual press release.

Don’t Drink and Drive: Assessing the Effectiveness of Anti-Drinking Campaigns

Grades: 9-12



Students deconstruct the different approaches that have been used by various organizations to reach teens and young adults and will debate those techniques that are most likely to resonate with youth. In a summative activity, groups of students create and implement an alcohol awareness campaign for students.

Editing Emotions

Grades: 5-9



In this lesson, students learn about the history of film editing and how shot composition, juxtaposition of images and the use of rhythm and repetition in film editing can affect the emotional impact of a film.

Exposing Gender Stereotypes

Grades: 8-9



In this lesson students take a look at their own assumptions about what it means to be a man, and what it means to be a woman. Students will begin to see how believing in stereotypes can lead to violence towards oneself and others.



Film Classification Systems in Québec

Grades: 11-12



In this lesson students learn about the systems used to classify films, TV programs and video games. Students are asked to take a critical look at the criteria applied to classify these media products, and then take into account and discuss the underlying social and political aspects arising from those systems.

Finding and Authenticating Online Information on Global Development Issues

Grades: 7-12



In this lesson students learn strategies for using the Internet effectively to research global development issues.

First Person

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson students consider diversity representation in video games by identifying examples of diversity in the games they play, comparing their findings to statistics on diversity in the Canadian population.

First, Do No Harm: Being an Active Witness to Cyberbullying

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students consider how difficult and complicated it can sometimes be to do the right thing. Students are asked to consider whether they agree with a number of widely-held moral principles and then are asked to consider a moral dilemma in which a number of moral principles are in conflict, reflecting on how their view of it may change based on the details of the scenario.

Free Speech and the Internet

Grades: 10-12



In this lesson students learn about the inherent tension within democratic societies between freedom of expression and freedom from hatred. They also learn how Canada has addressed these issues within the *Criminal Code of Canada*, the *Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms* and human rights legislation in Canada.

#ForYou: The Algorithm Game

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students play the educational card game *#ForYou: A Game About Algorithms* and use it as a prompt to learn about and discuss the role that algorithms, data collection, and machine learning play in their lives. After playing, they analyze the game as an example of a *serious game* and then design their own serious game to communicate some of what they have learned in the lesson.



Gambling in the Media

Grades: 9-12



This two-day lesson looks at the increasing prominence of gambling in the media, particularly movies and television. Students are asked to look critically at how gambling is portrayed, in comparison to its reality, and to consider how that portrayal affects how people perceive the risks and rewards of gambling.

Governance of Television and Radio Communications in Canada

Grades: 11-12



This lesson introduces students to the organizations of the Canadian broadcasting industry, and to the codes, guidelines and issues relating to violence, ethics, representation, advertising and the accuracy of news in television and radio programming.

Hate 2.0

Grades: 8-10



This lesson is designed to be delivered after students have completed at least one of the following lessons: Thinking About Hate, Scapegoating and Othering and Hate or Debate. In groups, students research an online environment (such as social networking sites) and a particular example of that environment (such as Facebook) to learn the issues, strategies and tools relating to online hate in that environment.

Hate or Debate?

Grades 8-10



In this lesson students learn about the difference between legitimate debate on a political issue and arguments that are based on hate.

Images of Learning

Grades: 9-12



This lesson helps students become more aware of the stereotypes associated with portrayals of students and teachers on television and on film.

I heard it 'round the Internet: Sexual health education and authenticating online information

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students consider the use of the Internet as a research tool and learn how to use search engines more effectively. They then apply these newfound skills to investigating popular myths about sexuality and contraception.



Impact! How to Make a Difference When You Witness Bullying Online

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students discuss reasons why they might be reluctant to intervene when they witness cyberbullying and identify ways that they can help without making things worse. They then use the interactive tool *Impact! How to Make a Difference When You Witness Bullying Online* to help them decide how to navigate scenarios relating to being a witness to bullying, and share their experiences to help them understand how important it is to think carefully before you act.

Introduction to Online Civic Engagement

Grades: 9-12



Students are introduced to civic education through a series of activities which will ask them to work together to engage with their larger communities through curiosity, conversation and creation.

Learning Gender Stereotypes

Grades: 8-9



Students deconstruct a series of advertisements based on gender representation and answer questions about gender stereotyping about articles they have read.

Making Media for Democratic Citizenship

Grades: 11-12



In this lesson students create a video podcast to present balanced, unbiased perspectives on global development issues. They voice their perspectives through the language, codes and conventions of a visual medium.

Making Your Voice Heard: A Media Toolkit for Youth

Grades: 9-12



This toolkit is designed to help young people understand how the news industry works, why youth stereotyping happens and how they can access media to get positive youth voices and stories heard.

Marketing to Teens: Alternate Ads

Grades: 8-12



In this lesson students look at the less obvious methods used by advertisers to reach consumers: humorous, self-deprecating ads, product placement, product association with celebrities, ads promoting empowerment and affirmation and 'advocacy' advertising.



Marketing to Teens: Gender Roles in Advertising

Grades: 8-12



Students explore gender roles in advertising by taking an ad campaign they have seen which is specifically directed to one gender, and redesigning the campaign to target the opposite gender.

Marketing to Teens: Gotta Have It! Designer and Brand Names

Grades: 8-12



Students identify how we associate social status with designer and brand name products, and how we believe others perceive us by what we wear.

Marketing to Teens: Marketing Tactics

Grades: 8-12



This activity helps teenagers develop an awareness of marketing tactics aimed at teens through the creation of their own mock advertising campaigns.

Marketing to Teens: Parody Ads

Grades: 8-12



In this lesson students explore what's hidden behind advertising messages by analysing and creating parody advertisements.

Marketing to Teens: Talking Back

Grades: 8-12



This lesson helps teens become active consumers by encouraging them to 'talk back' to advertisers when they have concerns.

Mixed Signals: Verifying Online Information

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students examine two websites about unlikely animals and learn how to effectively evaluate online sources. They then create a fake website that demonstrates the misleading signals that are often mistakenly taken as signs of reliability.



My Voice is Louder Than Hate: The Impact of Hate

Grades: 9-10



In this lesson, students explore how interacting through digital media can make it easier to hurt someone's feelings and can make hurtful or prejudiced behaviour seem normal in online spaces. They learn how Canadian youth feel about and respond to casual prejudice online and then use the *My Voice is Louder Than Hate* tool to create a digital story that will help people understand that online hate hurts everyone who witnesses it.

My Voice is Louder Than Hate: Pushing Back Against Hate

Grades: 9-10



In this lesson, students explore the benefits and drawbacks of being “full citizens” online. They learn reasons why Canadian youth sometimes do not push back when they witness casual prejudice online and then use the *My Voice is Louder Than Hate* tool to practice different ways of responding. Finally, students analyze memes as a medium and a way of responding to hate or other hurtful behaviour online and then use the *My Voice is Louder Than Hate* tool to create a meme that they can use to push back against causal prejudice.

Online Cultures and Values

Grades: 11-12



In this lesson, students are introduced to basic concepts of anthropology and ethnography and explore how they apply to online communities. After performing a digital ethnography project on the norms and values of an online community, students consider how a community's norms and values are formed and how they can be shaped and influenced.

Online Gambling and Youth

Grades: 11-12



In this lesson, students look at the ways in which online gambling draws in youth and increases the risk that they will become problem gamblers.

Online Marketing to Kids: Protecting Your Privacy

Grades: 6-9



This two lesson unit on online marketing explores the various ways companies use the Internet to target young people. The first lesson introduces students to the ways in which commercial websites collect personal information from kids and to the issues surrounding children and privacy on the Internet.



Online Marketing to Kids: Strategies and Techniques

Grades: 6-9



The second lesson in the Online Marketing to Kids unit introduces students to the online marketing techniques that are used to target children on the Internet.

Online Propaganda and the Proliferation of Hate

Grades: 10-12



In this lesson students learn about the ways that propaganda techniques are used to promote hatred and intolerance online.

Online Relationships: Respect and Consent

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson students use mind maps to explore concepts of “respect” and “consent” in an online context.

On the Loose: A Guide to Online Life for Post-Secondary Students

Grades: 11-12



This guide supports young adults who are experiencing both new freedoms and challenges in their post-secondary life. It covers a variety of digital issues that students may require guidance on, including: school work; money and security; relationships online; and trying to stay healthy.

Perceptions of Youth and Crime

Grades: 7-12



In this lesson students develop an awareness of the ways in which public perceptions regarding young people have been affected by media portrayals of youth violence and youth crime.

Police in Media

Grades: 7-12



This lesson helps students understand the different perceptions of the police force portrayed in the media. Students will learn about the differences between the constructed reality of media and law enforcement in real life and then create their television “cop shows” that provide a more accurate picture of policing.



Political Cartoons

Grades: 10-12



This lesson begins with a teacher-led deconstruction of a political cartoon, after which students decode editorial cartoons that they have selected.

Popular Music and Music Videos

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students examine the importance of videos to the music industry and the role that music plays in popular culture.

Privacy Rights of Children and Teens

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students learn ways to find out what personal information may or has been collected by platforms that they use, how to limit data collection about themselves, and the various forms of recourse that are available to them if they feel an organization is not respecting their rights.

Promoting Ethical Behaviour Online: My Virtual Life

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students learn about ways to manage their privacy and reputation online by exploring their digital presence and to make good choices about sharing other people's content online.

PushBack: Engaging in Online Activism

Grades: 7-9



This lesson explores how young people can use online media for activism on issues that matter to them.

Put Your Best Face Forward

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students start by discussing the phenomenon of “selfies” and serve as experts in advising the teacher on the standards by which the “best” selfies are judged. They then discuss a number of statements taken from interviews with youth that highlight issues of self-representation, body image and gender standards, and learn about “photoshopping” images.



Reality Check: Authentication 101

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students consider the different factors that make online sources reliable or unreliable. They then learn quick steps they can take to gauge an online source's reliability and practice these steps by playing an interactive online game. Finally, students create a media product to teach other students how to do one of the tactics they've learned.

Reality Check: Authentication and Citizenship

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students consider the ways in which misinformation can have an impact on history and politics. After discussing a number of historical examples of misinformation, they examine the ways in which news sources may be biased and use an interactive online game to practice skills in getting more context on a story.

Reality Check: Getting the Goods on Science and Health

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students start by considering the wide range of science and health information they are likely to encounter in news or through social media. They read an article on a scientific topic to help them understand the particular challenges of verifying science and health information and then use an educational computer game to practice skills in critically reading health and science stories. Finally, students compile a list of reliable sources they can turn to for verifying health and science stories.

Reality Check: News You Can Use

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students consider the meanings of the term "fake news" and learn facts about the news industry that will help them recognize legitimate sources of news.

Reality Check: We Are All Broadcasters

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students consider the ways in which our own biases can prevent us from being objective. They then learn ways to recognize and account for our biases and practice these by playing an interactive online game. Finally, students learn about how public service campaigns can change social norms and create their own PSA to promote ethical sharing of online information.

Relationships and Sexuality in Media

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson students learn to question media representations of gender, relationships and sexuality.



Remixing Media

Grades: 10-12



In this lesson, students examine different types of remixes – from works created by editing a single text to ones that draw inspiration from existing texts – in order to develop a definition of “remix.”

Respecting Yourself and Others Online Workshop

Grades: 7-10



This workshop provides tweens and young teens with strategies and knowledge that will help them respect themselves, respect others and respect the space when using social media.

Scapegoating and Othering

Grades: 8-10



In this lesson students develop a deeper understanding of scapegoating and othering and how these factors may contribute to the promotion of hatred and intolerance.

Screen Stigma: Looking at Mental Illness in Popular Media

Grades: 9-10



Students begin by viewing a slideshow that explores common stereotypes of mental illness and mental illness treatment in media. They read a prepared analysis of the portrayal of mental illness in a TV show popular with teens, then in a small group analyze another text of their choice. Finally, students create an annotated version of a scene or excerpt from a text in which they analyze and evaluate its portrayal of mental illness.

Screen Stigma: Looking at Mental Illness in the News

Grades: 9-10



In this lesson, students learn about the ways in which news coverage of an event or issue can be biased, focusing on the aspects of the medium and industry that can lead to bias. They read an article that examines the coverage of mental illness in the news and then participate in an interactive activity that lets them compose their own article. Finally, students find and analyze a recent news story on a mental health topic and write a letter either praising or critiquing it.

Secure Comics

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students read an interactive online comic that teaches them key concepts and skills relating to three cybersecurity topics: malware, passwords and privacy from geotracking devices. Following this, students research their own cybersecurity topics and learn how non-fiction comics are made in order to create their own Secure Comic.



Selling Tobacco

Grades: 7-10



In this lesson, students explore how tobacco advertising has evolved over the past century.

Sex in Advertising

Grades: 11-12



This lesson helps students understand the multiple meanings of sexuality, the ways in which the media capitalizes on sex to sell a wide variety of products and the value systems underlying sexualized media messages.

Sports Personalities in Magazine Advertising

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students explore the relationship between athletes and advertising through a number of different activities.

Shaking the Movers: Youth Rights and Media

Grades: 9-10



In this lesson students discuss the concept of human rights and then learn how these ideas led to the drafting of the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child.

Suffragettes and Iron Ladies

Grades: 10-12



This lesson considers how the media portrays women in politics.

Speak Up! Your Guide to Changing the World, Online and Off

Grades: 9-12



Thanks to the internet and social media, it's easier than ever to share your views and encourage others to join you in making change. This guide shows students the ways they can use social networks to make their voice heard and make a difference.



Taming the Wild Wiki

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students are introduced to Wikipedia, the user-edited online encyclopedia, and given an overview of its strengths and weaknesses as a research source. They are taught how to evaluate the reliability of a Wikipedia article and then attempt to improve an existing article.

Technology Facilitated Violence: Criminal Case Law Lesson Plan

Grades: 11-12



This lesson plan explores the relationship between technology and the law by examining how the criminal law responds to technologically facilitated violence (TFV). Students will use materials from The eQuality Project's "Technology-Facilitated Violence: Criminal Case Law" database to research recent Canadian case law involving TFV, better understand the concept of "violence" and the wide range of acts that fall within TFV, as well as the available criminal legal resources and potential outcomes for those affected.

The Citizen Reporter

Grades: 9-12



This lesson begins with a brief history of citizen journalism and a discussion of just what it is. Students are introduced to the key media literacy concept that media are constructions that re-present reality and consider how the traditionally "white" makeup of Canadian journalism might affect the content of Canadian news. They then discuss the effects of the increasing ability of ordinary citizens to cover, broadcast and comment on news and compare mainstream news sources and citizen journalism in terms of accuracy, completeness and diversity representation.

The Front Page

Grades: 9-12



This lesson begins by helping students to identify and understand the different aspects of the newspaper. Using these skills, students will then collect and identify front-page news stories and categorize them according to subject matter.

The Invisible Machine: Big Data and You

Grades: 8-10



In this lesson, students examine a fictional social network profile to learn how online platforms collect data about their users. They then read an article that explains how platforms use this data and explores some of the issues this raises. Finally, they create a mind map of their own online data profile and reflect on how the data they post may be collected and used by others.



The Price of Happiness

Grades: 8-12



Students answer a brief questionnaire related to self-image, self-esteem, and advertising, and then work as groups to create and act in mock television commercials that parody advertising techniques.

The Privacy Dilemma

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson students learn the ways that the apps they use are designed to encourage them to share more information—both with other users and with the apps themselves.

There's no excuse: confronting moral disengagement in sexting

Grades: 11-12



In this lesson, students learn about the “sneaky excuses” that can convince us to do things that we know are wrong. After learning about the different types of these excuses, students watch and discuss a series of videos in which the excuses are used to justify forwarding sexts without the original sender’s consent. Finally, students create their own videos in which the excuses used to justify sharing sexts with other people are illustrated and most importantly, countered.

Thinking About Hate

Grades: 8-10



In this lesson students develop their critical thinking skills by learning to recognize various types of bad faith arguments, including those that are used by hate mongers to spread misinformation and fuel hatred and intolerance.

Thinking Like a Tobacco Company

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson, students learn how the tobacco industry targets the needs, wishes and desires of young people in order to sell cigarettes. Students begin by looking at the reasons why the tobacco industry needs to recruit “replacement” smokers. Then they assume the roles of marketing personnel in a tobacco company and use a 1987 youth survey conducted by R. J. Reynolds Tobacco to create their own marketing campaigns to sway various sub-groups within the youth demographic.



Tobacco Labels

Grades: 6-9



Students debate the effectiveness of health warning labels on tobacco products. They begin by looking at different warning labels from around the world, and then focus specifically on Canada's new visual warning labels. Students discuss the elements of effective warning labels, and look at the difficulties of reaching young people with health messages.

Unpacking the Black Box: Explaining Algorithms and AI

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students learn about algorithms and AI, how they work, how they impact our lives on the internet, and ethical considerations. The lesson begins with a class discussion on algorithms. Students will discuss how AIs reinforce real-world biases, the difficulties in identifying how AIs make decisions, what information algorithms use to make choices, and how that information impacts the types of decisions AIs make. Finally, students will demonstrate their knowledge by researching and designing an infographic on a field that uses algorithms to make decisions. This lesson aims to build critical thinking skills by examining how AI algorithms work, investigating the biases and impacts of AI decision-making, and reflecting on how the implications to their own lives.

Video Games

Grades: 7-9



In this lesson students are introduced to the ways video games may impact their mental and physical health.

Watching the Elections

Grades: 8-12



Students look at how elections are media events, then compare American and Canadian elections to other mass media events and then watch one or both debates with an eye to analyzing them as media constructs. Students will then study advertising techniques frequently used in political ads, then watch American and Canadian campaign ads from past years.

Who's Telling My Story?

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson students learn about the history of blackface and other examples of majority-group actors playing minority-group characters such as White actors playing Asian and Indigenous characters and non-disabled actors playing disabled characters.



Writing a Newspaper Article

Grades: 6-9



The lesson begins with a discussion about freedom of speech and the important role it plays in journalism. Next, students will learn how to create news articles by developing 'lead paragraphs' and by using the 'inverted pyramid' model. Once this is done, they will be given time during class to select topics, conduct research, write their articles and proof read and peer edit their own and other's works.

Your Connected Life: A Teen's Guide to Life Online

Grades: 9



This guide is designed to help students who are just entering high school balance the demands of their offline life with their digital one.

Your Online Resume

Grades: 9-12



In this lesson, students learn that their online presence is like a resume that can help them – or hurt them – in their future personal and professional lives.

